

Chapter 117_1 - Explanation

"What else did Jiuying tell you?" Chu Qingqiu asked.

Qiu Yi stood up with her, shaking her head: "She didn't say much more. But Master, you shouldn't worry too much either. I always feel that Jiuying is full of half-truths, and what she said might not be anything more than lies to deceive me."

"I know." Chu Qingqiu said.

At this moment, the great door was suddenly knocked upon. Qiu Yi looked up alertly, only to see a jade-white hand extend through the black door crack, holding a jade plate with some pastries and tea, quietly entering.

Bare feet stirred up snow-white skirts as the great door closed again. The woman gracefully walked to the stone table, waved her hand to clear away the mess, and placed the jade plate upon it.

Qiu Yi took two steps forward to stand in front of Chu Qingqiu, glaring at Du Baishuang who had suddenly appeared here, her face full of wariness.

Du Baishuang saw her rejection but didn't mind. She simply covered her lips and smiled, curtsying gracefully.

"Du Baishuang greets Divine Venerable Chu Ling." She smiled sweetly, her smile charming and graceful on her face, her movements like willows swaying in the wind - light and gentle.

"No need for such formality." Chu Qingqiu said indifferently. "Did Ning Fuyi send you?"

"No." Du Baishuang shook her head, the two strings of beads on her ears swaying with her movement. "This slave heard that the Divine Venerable was alone here and feared you might not be accustomed to this cold underground palace, so I came specially to keep you company."

"I'm here to accompany Master. We don't need you." Qiu Yi found that face strange to look at and said with her chin raised.

Du Baishuang smiled as she looked at her, then at Chu Qingqiu, her smile becoming even more animated: "Divine Venerable, this slave has some words I'd like to speak with you alone."

Chu Qingqiu looked at her for a few moments, then said: "Qiu Yi, you may go."

Though Qiu Yi was worried about Chu Qingqiu, she dared not disobey, so she could only leave reluctantly, looking back with every step.

"Whatever you have to say, speak." Chu Qingqiu supported herself on her knees as she sat down.

Du Baishuang's gaze never left her face. After a moment, she laughed coldly and sighed as if moved: "Divine Venerable's face is truly beautiful - cold and elegant. One can tell at a glance that you're a deity from heaven, high and unattainable."

Chu Qingqiu frowned and looked up: "Your appearance is very similar to mine. Why speak so?"

Du Baishuang's mouth corners turned up high as she slowly walked to the table, smiling: "Indeed very similar. If not for this face, I fear I wouldn't have received even a glance of concern from her until death."

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips trembled slightly, a stern look in her eyes.

"What exactly do you want to say?"

"I don't want to say anything special. It's just that my thoughts have been bottled up for so long, I wanted to find someone to confide in." Du Baishuang moistened her red lips, half-kneeling as she sat down, her elbow propped on the stone table, leaning softly against it.

"Does the Divine Venerable know what it feels like to love someone - that kind of love that's forever hidden in corners, forever unattainable?" Du Baishuang blinked her eyes. "I knew then that I was just a substitute¹. Every night when she wanted my company, she would often look at me, but that gaze always passed through me, never landing in my eyes."

Chu Qingqiu gripped her clothes tightly.

"I despised my spirit clan identity. My fate was nothing more than being devoured, or refined, or worse yet, being imprisoned for cultivation use, never seeing daylight again."

"After a long time, I had become accustomed to it. After all, the world is unfair - some are born as deities, others are born like livestock. When I was sent to her side as a spy, I almost thought she would immediately devour me or make me suffer endless torment, becoming her cultivation tool."

"After all, she was the demon despised by the world. How could she be kinder than those immortals?" Du Baishuang spoke softly, her eyes showing an indissoluble attachment.

"But she didn't. She only called me Shuang'er² and prepared the best food, clothing, and necessities for me. Though she didn't like me, how respectful she was toward me." Du Baishuang's beads under her ears swayed gently as she smiled sweetly. "So I obediently served as her substitute. I knew I couldn't compare to the person in her eyes, but being able to stay by her side for a while, I was content."

"In any case, it was just death. Dying by her hand, I would also be content." She said softly.

Chu Qingqiu felt her heart become stuffy and blocked. She closed her eyes to block out the dancing lamplight, pretending not to understand what she was saying.

"I know the Divine Venerable doesn't understand, but that's not important." Du Baishuang took a piece of pastry and put it in her mouth. "What's important is that I actually had the chance to see her again, and also see the person she truly wanted to see - indeed a thousand, a hundred times better than me."

"This time I can't even serve as a substitute anymore, but I still love her."

The hall fell into complete silence, with only the sound of the woman's breathing. Du Baishuang finished the pastry in her mouth, clapped her hands and stood up, gracefully curtsying to her again.

"The Hall Master has also assigned tasks to this slave, so I won't accompany you further. Divine Venerable, please enjoy at your leisure."

Having said this, she departed gracefully, leaving only Chu Qingqiu sitting in place, slowly loosening her tightly gripped hands.

At the same time, at the other end of the underground palace, Ning Fuyi held a secret report, rubbing the ring left by her spike weapon between her fingers, her expression grave.

"Why was it only reported now that Medical Immortal Jiang disappeared for so long?" Ning Fuyi looked at Han Ya.

Han Ya's head was almost hanging to her chest as she said carefully: "Because the Jiang family originally didn't know that Medical Immortal Jiang was missing. They only thought she had left in anger. It wasn't until yesterday when they received a blood letter³ asking for help that they panicked. Now they're asking the six sects to help find Medical Immortal Jiang's whereabouts."

"This news quickly reached Flying Swallow Residence⁴, and the people there wrote a letter to report it to Chuwei Hall." Han Ya said.

Ning Fuyi's brow furrows grew deeper. That day at Danding Manor, facing thousands of people in such chaotic circumstances, she truly hadn't noticed where Jiang Li was, assuming she had been standing in the Jiang family's elegant pavilion all along, unable to show herself.

How could a perfectly good living person disappear into thin air? Those present that day were either people from immortal sects or from Penglai. The immortal sect people had no grudges with her and had even received many favors from her - it would be hard to make enemies.

Then this matter was most likely related to Penglai.

But why would Penglai people capture Jiang Li? Ning Fuyi was also momentarily confused, unable to help but suspect it was Penglai's scheme.

"Also, spies from Penglai have sent back news saying that ever since being outmaneuvered by Master at Danding Manor, Emperor Tianrui has been furious and has been in closed-door cultivation for many days, not knowing what he's planning." Han Ya added.

"That's as it should be." Ning Fuyi put away the secret report and smiled. "Penglai originally thought they could use this opportunity to righteously bring me, this demon seed, to justice. But they never expected me to turn the tables on them. Not only did they fail to force out my demon roots in front of all the immortal sects, but they also ruined their own reputation."

"From now on, when Penglai speaks, it won't be as effective as before. This title of 'First in the Six Realms' that he gained through opportunism can be considered lost." Ning Fuyi's eyebrows curved slightly as she waved her hand at Han Ya.

"I understand about Jiang Li's matter. You may go now." She said.

Footnotes

- ¹ **Substitute (替身)** - In this context, Du Baishuang refers to herself as someone used to replace or stand in for another person, specifically someone who resembles Chu Qingqiu physically.
- ² **Shuang'er (双儿)** - An affectionate diminutive form of Du Baishuang's name, literally meaning "little Shuang."
- ³ **Blood letter (血书)** - A letter written in blood, typically used to convey extreme urgency or desperation in Chinese culture.
- ⁴ **Flying Swallow Residence (飞燕居)** - One of Ning Fuyi's information-gathering establishments or network locations.